

on screen area: just two inches. If you like to zoom into the action, the Canon A530 sports the largest optical zoom (4x) in this group. The others all manage with 3x.

A noteworthy feature on the Olympus SP-310 was its support for the RAW format in addition to the usual JPEG, which all 23 cameras

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Sony DSC L1
A petite performer

supported. RAW is an uncompressed format unlike JPEG, and this feature is usually present only on professional-grade cameras.

High-End Cameras

Populated by eight models, this is the segment where we focus more on performance and less on value. In the major league, two players were really well represented—Kodak and Canon had three models each. Sony had one—the W-50—as did Samsung with its S-800. Premier made yet another appearance with their top-end DS-8650.

We liked the menu layout of the Canon A700 in particular. This intuitive layout is shared by the other Canon models as well, but the large 2.5 inch screen makes all the difference. Sony's W-50 has an excellent screen as well, 2.5 inches of pure viewing bliss! We also liked the W-50's layout, which happens to be common to all the cameras we received from them. The W50 has excellent ergonomics as well, button feedback especially the half click at which your camera's lens starts auto-focusing is tactile to say the least. The navigation



Kodak V-570
Those dual-shooters ain't doin' much!

buttons on the A700 (Canon) and the S800 (Samsung) were also rather nicely laid out and comfortable to use. On the DS-8650, Premier follows the same, rather simple menu of the lower-end models. The DS-8650 deserves special mention for its LCD, the largest among the crop we received at 2.8 inches, (the Kodak V610 was the only other model with a screen so large). We found the Kodak screens in general to be good, —nothing really fancy, though they get the job done.

No competition for the best looking this side of town: the Sony W-50 stomps all over the others in this regard! It's sleek, and the satiny black finish oozes quality (it's also available in silver). We even found the sticker on the Sony to suit its overall looks (some other models had rather garish stickers). For such a small footprint, the Sony W50 feels solid to hold. Another solid little thing is the Canon Digital Ixus 60, which is even smaller than the Sony while maintaining a large feature set. These two (the W-50 and the Ixus 60) were the smallest cameras in this category.

Canon PowerShot S3-IS

The biggest and costliest camera in our test, the S3-IS doesn't fit into any of the categories of camera we received. Priced at Rs 32,995, the S3-IS definitely isn't cheap. Canon positions this model as a true intermediate offering, bridging the gap between the compact cameras for casual clickers and the bulkier professional-grade cameras that are beyond most users' financial boundaries!



Canon has excelled here as far as design goes. The camera is a sober black—inconspicuous compared to the S2-IS, which is a flashy silver. The S3-IS is very nicely contoured and easy to grip, even more so because of the non-slip soft grip material used on the areas of the body where your hands are most likely to be. The controls are perfectly laid out. Under the hood, the S3-IS features the same Digic II processor that Canon has dropped under the bonnet of all cameras in their PowerShot range.

The S3-IS offers six megapixels, up from the five that its predecessor, the S2-IS, offered. A two inch swivel and twist action LCD ensures you can see what you shoot at from nearly every conceivable angle. 12x optical zoom means you can get up close to the action. The camera also features image stabilisation—good for those with shaky hands.

The S3's performance was excellent during our outdoor shoot: we were amazed at the clarity of the long-range zoom—perfect for the adventurer who doesn't want to burn too large a hole in his pocket! It was a touch disappointing to discover that the intrepid (and expensive) S3 didn't perform as well indoors. Our test scene with the fruit basket was used, and as you will see (test shots of all cameras will be included on next month's DVD), the S3 produced an image with slight amounts of graininess. We did a double take just to be sure. The indoor macro scene was quite similar results-wise. The outdoor macro was a runaway hit—no noticeable faults at all. To be quite frank, the indoor results weren't all that bad; it's just that we expected so much more from a 30,000+ camera!

A good buy if you're looking at a lot of outdoor shooting—read natural light. It's a slightly different story once you get indoors.

In fact, the outdoors guy *is* the camera's intended audience—whether the S3 spells value for money depends on how you plan to use it.